

Neighbours

~ Tim Winton

• Characters

- The Young Couple
- The Macedonian Family
- The Polish Widower
- Midwife etc.

• Setting

→ The story is set in a small, multicultural suburb near Moreton Bay in Australia, an area populated largely by European immigrants. The neighbourhood consists of closely packed houses, where the young couple lives in a small house, surrounded by neighbours from different backgrounds.

GSS_Notes

• Plot

→ A young couple moves into a busy, friendly neighborhood full of people from different countries. At first, they feel like they do not belong and they judge their neighbours for being too loud and different. As time passes, they start to talk to their neighbours through the fence while gardening or fixing their home. These small acts of kindness help them become friends. When the couple has a baby, the whole neighbourhood comes together to help and celebrate with them. The couple realizes they are no longer outsiders, but part of a caring family.

• Understanding the text

Answer the following questions.

a) Describe how the young couple's house looked like.

Ans. The couple lived in a small, modest, and elegant house. It felt very different from the spacious suburban homes they were used to. Because the houses in the area were built very close together, their home lacked privacy. They could hear everything happening next door, and their neighbours could easily see into their space. It was a simple, traditional structure that felt small and exposed compared to the life they had previously known.

b) How did the young couple identify their neighbours in the beginning of their arrival?

Ans. When they first arrived, the couple identified their neighbours by their cultural backgrounds and their loud, boisterous behaviors, rather than as individuals. They saw them as a 'Macedonian family' who were noisy and a 'polish widower' who was always hammering. They viewed these neighbours as strange, "alien" people whose lives were too busy and intrusive. The couple felt like superior outsiders, judgemental of the unfamiliar habits and traditions they observed from their own home.

c) How did the neighbours help the young couple in the kitchen garden?

Ans. When the couple started their garden in autumn, they were inexperienced. The neighbours noticed this and began offering practical help. They didn't just watch; they came over to give advice on planting, hilling and mulching. They shared their own gardening secrets and provided the expertise the couple lacked. This friendly interference turned a private task into a shared neighbourhood project, helping the couple learn how to grow their own food while breaking down social barriers.

d) Why were the people in the neighbourhood surprised at the role of the young man and his wife in their family?

Ans. The neighbours ~~had~~ were surprised because the couple's lifestyle went against the traditional roles they were used to. In this community, men were usually the ones working while women managed the home. However, in this couple's house, the wife went out to work while the husband stayed home to write his thesis. The neighbors found this switch very unusual, as it was the opposite of the traditional immigrant lifestyle they followed and valued at the time.

e) How did the neighbors respond to the woman's pregnancy?

Ans. The neighbour responded with great warmth

and excitement. Physically, they brought gifts of food, baby clothes, and hand-knitted items. Emotionally, they showed genuine joy and shared the couple's anticipation, acting like extended family members. They stopped being distant and instead became very involved, offering advice and support. The pregnancy removed the last bit of social distance, as the entire community focused their collective love and care on the arrival of the new baby.

f) Why did the young man begin to weep at the end of the story?

Ans At the end of the story, the young man cries because he is overwhelmed by the kindness of his neighbors. He realizes that his initial judgement and feelings of superiority were wrong. As he watches the community come together to support him and his wife during the birth, he feels a deep sense of belonging and humility. He is moved by the realization that love and human connection are far more important than any cultural differences.

g) Why do you think the author didn't characterize the person in the story with proper name?

Ans The author likely chose not to use proper names to make the characters feel more universal. By calling them "the young man",

"the wife", "the macedonian family" or "the polish widower", the story focuses on the roles people play rather than their specific identities. It highlights that the struggle to belong and the joy of community are human experiences that could happen to anyone, anywhere, regardless of their individual name or specific cultural origins.

- Reference to the content

a) The story shows that linguistic and cultural barriers do not create any obstacle in human relationship. Cite some examples from the story where the neighbours have transcended such barriers. GSS Notes

Ans In Neighbours, the couple and their neighbours often do not share a common language, yet they build deep bonds through actions rather than words. For example, when the couple's DIY henhouse collapses, the polish widower doesn't need to explain how to fix it; he simply walks over and builds it for them. This silent, practical act shows his willingness to help without needing conversation.

Similarly, when the couple begins their kitchen garden, they are clueless about how to manage the soil. The neighbors immediately step in, showing them how to till and mulch the plants. By sharing tools and techniques, they bridge the gap between their different backgr-

ounds.

Finally, the pregnancy acts as the ultimate unifier. Without needing to speak the same language, the ultimate unifier. Without needing to speak the same language, the neighbors share their excitement through food, gifts and hand-made baby clothes. These gestures prove that kindness is a universal language that easily bypasses the walls created by different cultures.

b) The last sentence of the story reads "the twentieth-century novel had not prepared him for this." In ~~th~~ your view, what differences did the young man find between twentieth-century novels and human relations?

Ans: The young man's comment suggests that literature often portrays life as complex, dramatic or intellectual, whereas real-life human ~~con~~ connection is often simple, instinctive, and raw. Many 20th century novels focus on the loneliness of the individual or the struggle to find meaning in a complicated world, often highlighting misunderstandings and the impossibility of true connection between different types of people.

In contrast, the reality he experiences in his neighborhood is surprisingly straightforward. He realizes that human relationships do not require grand philosophies or perfectly written dialogues to function. Instead, they thrive on

basic, physical acts of support -like helping a neighbor plant a garden or holding a hand during childbirth.

Ultimately, he finds that literature focuses too much on the "why" of human behavior, while real life is defined by the "how" of just being there for each other in moments of need.

c) A Nepali proverb says "Neighbors are companions for wedding procession as well as for funeral procession." Does this proverb apply in the story? Justify.

GSS_Notes

Ans: The Nepali proverb, "Neighbors are companions for wedding as well as for funeral procession," emphasizes that neighbors are the people who stand by you during both life's greatest joys and its deepest sorrows. This applies perfectly to the story. The neighbors are present for the celebration of the new baby, which is a joyful "wedding-like" milestone for the young couple.

Throughout the year, they also provide support through the "sorrows" of life - such as the couple's initial feelings of isolation, their failures in building the henhouse, and the anxiety of the birth itself. The neighbors prove that they are the primary support system, always ready to step over the fence to help.

Just as the proverb suggests, the neighbors in the story show that distance from family is

bridged by the people living next door, who become a permanent, reliable presence in every stage of life.

Q The author has dealt with an issue of multiculturalism in the story. Why do you think multiculturalism has become a major issue in the present world?

Ans. Multiculturalism has become a major global issue because our world is more connected than ever before. People move across borders for work, safety, and a better life, leading to communities where different traditions, religions, and languages live side-by-side. While this diversity brings richness, it can also lead to misunderstanding and fear of the "other", much like the couple's initial feelings in the story.

The challenge today is to build societies where these differences are celebrated rather than feared. When people do not understand each other's customs, it is easy to build mental "walls" that create tension & conflict.

As shown in Winton's story, the solution is proximity and participation. When we interact with those from different cultures through daily life, we realize our shared humanity. Learning to live together in a diverse world is essential for peace, as it turns potential ~~enemies~~ enemies into neighbors and friends.